JANUARY 2026

STUDENT PRICE INDEX (SPI) UPDATE

The January 2026 Central Washington University Student Price Index (CWU SPI) shows a 0.5% increase in the cost of living compared to December 2025. The most notable price changes were observed in beer, gasoline, and groceries. While grocery and gasoline prices declined over the month, beer prices rose sharply by 11.2%, likely driven by seasonal demand, distributor price adjustments at the start of the year, and promotional pricing ending after the holidays. Overall, the CWU SPI increased by the same rate as the Pacific Northwest CPI (0.5%), while the national CPI rose more slowly, recording a 0.2% increase.

INFLATION RATES

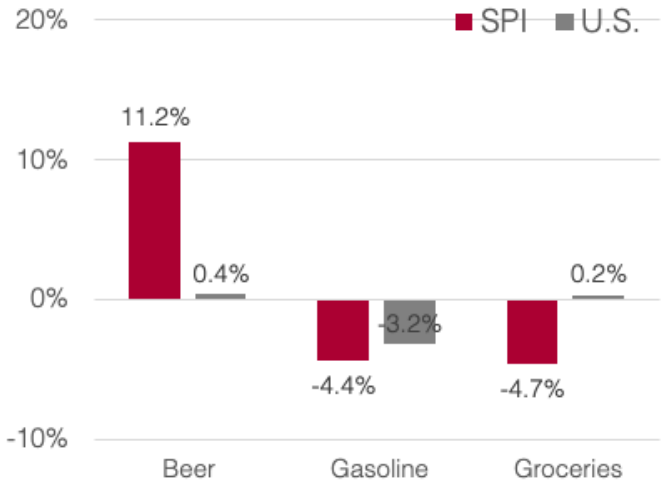
ANNUAL

Central Washington University Student Price Index (SPI)	**-6.3 %**
Pacific Region (CPI)[1]	**2.9 %**
United States (CPI)[2]	**2.4 %**

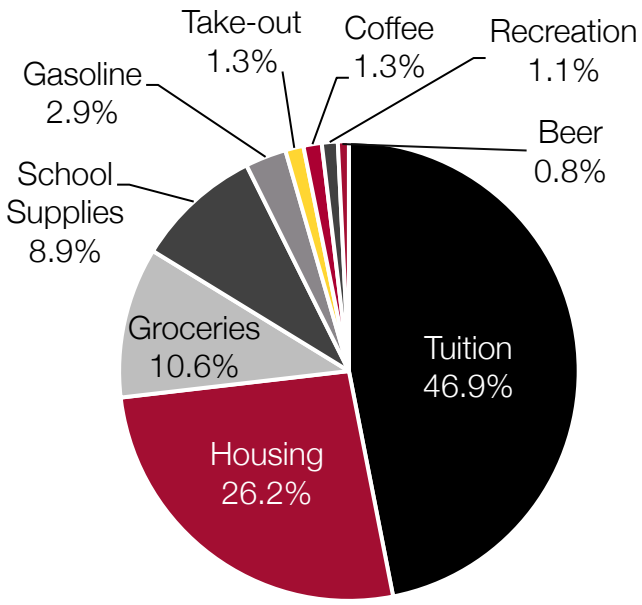
MONTHLY

Central Washington University Student Price Index (SPI)	**0.5 %**
Pacific Region (CPI)[1]	**0.5 %**
United States (CPI)[2]	**0.2 %**

MAIN CONTRIBUTORS (MONTHLY)



CATEGORIES AND WEIGHTS



Last update: Fall 2022

1. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics, Consumer Price Index, Pacific Division (AK, CA, HI, OR, WA).
2. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics, Consumer Price Index, All Urban Consumers

THE SPI PROJECT

This project, led jointly by the Economics Association and the Department of Economics at CWU, develops a price index of the cost of college living in Ellensburg, Washington. Based on the campus-wide survey, each month the members of the Economic Association collect prices of items typically consumed by CWU students from various stores in Ellensburg to calculate the SPI index and inflation rates. This index's strength lies in identifying the change in prices students in Ellensburg face.

Contributors

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